

Heart Disease Overview and Statistics:

Heart disease is the leading cause of death for men, women, and people of most racial and ethnic groups in the United States. Coronary artery disease (CAD) is the most common form of heart disease, responsible for the vast majority of myocardial infarctions (heart attacks). CAD occurs when the arteries that supply blood to heart muscle become hardened and narrowed due to plaque buildup.

Major Modifiable Risk Factors:

Three key risk factors are widespread in the general population:

1. High Blood Pressure (Hypertension): Damaging and weakening vascular endothelial lining.
2. High Blood Cholesterol (Elevated LDL): Providing the raw lipid substrate that forms atherosclerotic plaques.
3. Tobacco Smoking: Damaging blood vessels, accelerating plaque formation, and decreasing arterial oxygen levels.

Other contributing health conditions include type 2 diabetes, obesity, physical inactivity, and diets high in saturated fats, trans fats, and sodium.

Recognizing Heart Attack Symptoms:

A heart attack (myocardial infarction) occurs when blood flow to a section of the heart muscle is abruptly blocked. Common symptoms include:

- Chest Discomfort: Uncomfortable pressure, squeezing, fullness, or center chest pain lasting more than a few minutes.
- Radiating Discomfort: Pain or aching in one or both arms, the back, neck, jaw, or upper stomach.
- Shortness of Breath: With or without chest discomfort.
- Other Signs: Cold sweats, nausea, lightheadedness, or sudden unexplained fatigue.

***Emergency Action*:** Call 911 immediately if heart attack symptoms occur.

Evidence-Based Prevention:

- Choose heart-healthy nutrition: Prioritize fresh produce, whole grains, and lean proteins while minimizing sodium and saturated fats.
- Maintain a healthy body weight and target a normal BMI.
- Engage in regular physical activity (minimum 150 min/week).
- Quit smoking and avoid exposure to secondhand smoke.
- Schedule routine preventive screenings for blood pressure, blood glucose, and lipid profiles.